

pologist Karl Polanyi's insight that labour markets are inherently local, not abstract national aggregates and that a "worm's eye view" of entrepreneurs' daily challenges offers far more actionable policy insights than a distant "bird's eye view." Notably, 80% of India's 26,134 employer-related legal provisions and 65% of its 69,233 employer compliances could be streamlined at the state level. Implementing a unified grid—State Employer Compliance Grid, modelled on the Digital Public Infrastructure's open-architecture—simplifies compliance processes, including filing returns and issuing licences, registrations, and permissions, enabling efficient end-to-end digital processing. International experience supports this approach. Decentralisation involves devolving regulatory and fiscal powers so states can address local bottlenecks in land use, skilling, and compliance. States with greater labour flexibility and policy autonomy consistently attract more manufacturing and private investment.

### DEEPENING HUMAN CAPITAL

Human capital is the only renewable source of energy for any country. India stands at a demographic crossroads; 65% of our population is under 35 (nearly 900 mn youth). Nearly 12 million people enter the workforce each year, but only a fraction receive formal skilling. India's dependency ratio (46.2) is lower than China's (45.9) and far below Japan's (68.4), underscoring the growth potential if this workforce is effectively skilled. Despite high enrolment rates, the employability of Indian graduates can be better. Globally this gap is bridged through strong academia-industry linkages. Germany's dual apprenticeship model remains a benchmark. For In-



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dia, the challenge is not just access, but also aligning education with sectors such as manufacturing, green energy, and digital services. Degree apprenticeships—structured as tripartite agreements between employers, universities, and students—offer a self-healing skilling model built on five principles: learning while earning, learning by doing, degree integration, multi-modal delivery, and industry-recognised certification.

India will soon be the third-largest economy in the world, but

we will still rank above 100 in per-capita income. Mass prosperity will come from higher productivity of our states, firms, and citizens that the three pillar detailed above will deliver. All three require breaking with the past, taking on vested interests, and imagining a new firm ecosystem with the fierce urgency of now. This need courage but our ancestors reminded us that *Veer Bhogya Vasundhara*. The Brave shall inherit the earth. **BT**

*Views are personal*